



As cheap as it gets
Motorola has earned the 'economical' tag deservedly.
<http://digit.in/1EWU01R>



LOL Mania

One atom told another, "I think I've lost an electron." Are you sure? I'm absolutely positive."

DO

The Android Dilemma: 10 problems that need fixing

Android is the largest computing platform in the world and because of that, it also has a bunch of problems that need to be understood.

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Let's begin this story with some stats:

- **Android's global market share in 2014: 76.6%**
- **No. of Android smartphones shipped in 2014: over 1 billion**
- **No. of active Android users in a month: over 1 billion**
- **No. of apps available on the Play Store: 1.5 million**

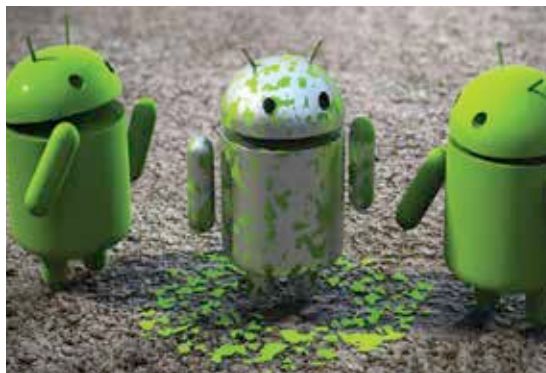
The above numbers represent something massive, something reminiscent of Microsoft during its heyday. They also prove beyond doubt that Android is the single most popular mobile platform today. On the flipside, Android does exhibit certain inherent flaws. Many of these flaws exist because of nobody's fault, neither Google's nor Android as an OS; they exist because of Android's size and reach and are therefore, unavoidable. The point of this story is to highlight these flaws, which, we believe, can be improved upon in time.

To sum it up, the flaws do not lie within Android itself, but rather arise because of where Android is at its current moment.

Still on the same page? Then let's go.

The Fragmentation Problem

Fragmentation is one of the biggest headaches that Google has to deal with. What this means is that there is such a vast array of Android devices with different features that it becomes difficult for Google or Android developers to efficiently release software for them. Open Signal states that in eight months of 2014 alone, there were 18,796 different Android devices



in existence globally, only 21% of which ran the latest Android version at that time.

Of course, the same fragmentation that can be a bane for developers, is a boon for consumers because it means that they get access to a wider range of devices for all markets.

Fragmentation is an issue that gives birth to other problems facing Android, problems that Google should tackle (and have begun to tackle).

Fixing fragmentation: Forks

The most immediate way that Android manufacturers try to differentiate their devices from others is with customized user interfaces. These interfaces don't just

change the way the phone's UI looks but also the way you use the phone. Prime examples of these are Samsung's TouchWiz, HTC's Sense and CyanogenMod. Now whether these are true 'forks' of Android is a debate for another day. What matters right now is that these interfaces present a bunch of different faces of Android to the end-user. If a layperson previously owned the original Motorola Moto G bought the Huawei Honor 6, you can't blame them if they're stumped by the UI, despite being on Android.

This confusion is further intensified by the numerous homebrewn core apps that Android manufacturers bundle with their devices. If, for instance, someone owned an HTC phone and liked BlinkFeed, they'd be disappointed if they didn't find it in an Android phone from another manufacturer. Google also has no control over the way, or the time in which these homebrewn apps are updated to stay perfectly compatible with newer versions of Android. Other times these apps function as pure bloatware (such as ChatOn or LenovoNQ).

The Solution: Google is already trying to mitigate the effects of software and UI fragmentation in a couple of ways. One, with the help of the Google Now launcher, users get the experience of Lollipop on any Android phone. Two, Google also appears committed to its line-up of Nexus devices so that there's a device in the market that runs Android the way Google expects it to be run.

Unfortunately, Google's device sales are nowhere near that of companies like Samsung, HTC and LG. Therefore, Google



A chart showing the fragmentation of Android.